The Sixties

For Erich and Margot Honecker, 1960 began with a drastic change of lifestyle when Politburo members were moved to a densely wooded settlement in Wandlitz, near the B109, north of Berlin. In this high-walled stronghold, camouflaged as a ‘wildlife research area’, the SED hierarchy lived a gilded existence, safe from their fellow countrymen.1 The couple was installed into a suburban-looking house on Habichtweg, next door to Ulbricht and his wife Lotte, only separated by a thin line of bushes. Erich Mielke lived at House 14, located at the extreme north-west corner of the settlement; his only direct neighbour was Honecker’s ex-wife Edith Baumann, who moved in with daughter Erica.2

The Honecker house had just seven rooms – 180 square meters of living space – and a small private garden and patio (strangely enough, there were garden gates, but no fences). The inner ring, where the functionaries lived, was surrounded by a high concrete wall secured by a state security guard regiment. Honecker paid a monthly rent of 370 marks for the house, furniture, and fittings.3 Although his main residence for nearly three decades, he later claimed to loathe Wandlitz; its only advantage, he asserted, was being able to sleep well, awake rested and be in Berlin within half an hour. This daily commute, according to his bodyguard, Bernd Bruckner, involved racing to the capital at 130 km/h, while in contrast, Margot explicitly told her driver to obey traffic regulations and not drive faster than 100 km/h, even on the highway.4

Although detached from the buzz of Berlin, there were compensations at Wandlitz; notably an onsite spa, heated swimming pool, sauna, supermarket (selling Western goods), medical centre, hairdressing salon, tailor’s shop, locksmith, laundry, canteen, bowling green, cinema and garden centre. Residents were spared nothing, there was even a garage with its own petrol station also available for tenants.